50TH ANNIVERSARY

CORRUPTION
2005-2015

Mega-scams shattered state credibility, paralysed governance and ignited mass anti-corruption protests, turning graft into a political liability that eroded trust, weakened institutions and damaged the ruling establishment



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THE 2G SPECTRUM ALLOCATION OF 2008 BECAME EMBLEMATIC OF HOW PUBLIC RESOURCES WERE MONETISED FOR PRIVATE GAIN

This was a decade when corruption did not merely recur as a familiar pathology of Indian governance. It metastasised into a defining political condition—eroding the moral authority of the state, paralysing decision-making and eventually producing the most sustained mass uprising against graft since Independence.

The rot became visible first in sectors where policy discretion met explosive economic growth. Telecom was the earliest and most devastating example. The 2G spectrum allocation of 2008, carried out on a first-come-first-served basis at 2001 prices, became emblematic of how public resources were monetised for private gain. The Comptroller and Auditor General estimated a presumptive loss of Rs 1.76 lakh crore, a figure that entered political folklore and dominated public discourse.

What made the scandal politically lethal was not just Union minister A. Raja's alleged role, but the perception that the highest offices of government had looked away. The silence of the Prime Minister's Office, despite multiple warnings from within the system, turned an administrative scandal into a crisis of integrity. The scandal shattered the UPA's claim to probity. Arrests followed, including that of Raja and DMK MP Kanimozhi, and the judiciary took an unusually interventionist role. In 2012, the Supreme Court cancelled 122 telecom licences, declaring the allocation process arbitrary and unconstitutional.

Barely had the hullabaloo over telecom subsided than another face of corruption emerged in the preparations for the 2010 Commonwealth Games. Intended as India's coming-out party as a global power, the Games instead revealed inflated contracts, shoddy construction and brazen rent-seeking. Organising Committee chairman Suresh Kalmadi was sacked, arrested and jailed. Images of collapsing footbridges and filthy athletes' villages became metaphors for governance failure.

Then came coal. The allocation of coal blocks between 2005 and 2009, many of them when PM Manmohan Singh concurrently held the charge of coal ministry, revealed a discretionary regime that favoured select private players without competitive bidding. An internal government review recommended cancellation of most allotments, while the CAG